

BULLU RAJ

Save Manipur

It's tough to live in Manipur in this day and age. And tougher, if one belongs to one of the country's smallest communities. Obed Kharam is from the Kharam tribe, which has fewer than 1,200 members. The postgraduate student of political science at Manipur University feels extremely marginalised. For, his community hardly gets any share of the multiple welfare schemes for tribals. "The larger tribal groups corner the benefits. We can't compete," says Kharam of Tuisenphai village in Kangpokpi district.

But, in this election, he will vote for a leader who can find a solution to the ethnic conflict and raise Manipur's voice in Parliament. Though he acknowledges the Centre's special attention to the Northeast, there is a deep pain in his heart. "The ethnic conflicts have stalled everything. There is so much hatred and distrust among communities. Yet, Prime Minister Narendra Modi could not find time to visit the state once in 11 months," laments Kharam. ■

-Kaushik Deka

OBED KHARAM, 23
Student

Lok Sabha constituency: Inner Manipur, Manipur

Top 3 demands: A liberal and secular India, employment and empowerment of youth, protection and mainstreaming of marginalised communities

What will influence his vote: A candidate's quest for peace in Manipur and his/her ability to raise voice in Parliament

CULTIVATING A NEW APPROACH

Jaskaranpreet farms a five-acre plot on the outskirts of Amritsar with his father, while his younger brother moved to England three years back to work as a driver. "No one wants to go out; if we can earn more here, we would prefer that," he says, adding that the farm sector in Punjab needed a better marketing ecosystem and infrastructure for greater diversification and higher returns. "Our state is going through a lot of churn.

JASKARANPREET SINGH, 22
Farmer, Jagdev Kalan, Amritsar

Lok Sabha constituency: Amritsar, Punjab

Top 3 demands: Boost for entrepreneurship, assured MSP for farm & dairy products, platform for grievances

What will influence his vote: Pro-farmer policies

AN AGENDA FOR THE NEW



Five years ago, confesses Mihir Ranjan, he was an "uninformed" first-time voter. That has changed. Part of the League of Legends Esports (or electronic sports) team that represented India at the Asian Games in Hangzhou last year, Ranjan, the son of teachers, now follows the speeches of external affairs minister S. Jaishankar: "Strong, powerful and assertive stances navigating a complex geopolitical

MIHIR RANJAN, 23
Gamer/ MBA student

Lok Sabha constituency: South Delhi, Delhi

Top 3 demands: Long-term planning for urban areas, training programme and infrastructure for the gaming industry, greater equality in society

What will influence his vote: A party's vision and ideology, and someone who is at the heart of what India stands for and who inspires the masses as PM candidate